

TCM NATURAL HEALTH PRESENTS

The Complete TCM Food Temperature Guide

*Hot, Warm, Cool & Cold — Understanding Your Food's
Hidden Energy*

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PUBLISHED BY TCM NATURAL HEALTH

The Complete TCM Food Temperature Guide

Based on the work and clinical practice of Dr. Timothy Yeh

Published by TCM Natural Health

tcmnaturalhealth.com

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

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Dr. Timothy Yeh was the President of the Yeh Center of Natural Medicine in Upland, California. Over the course of five decades, he treated more than 500,000 patients using a system that combined twelve types of natural medicine into a single, integrated approach.

He developed the Five Step Model of Systematic Natural Medicine and his proprietary diagnostic method, Causenosis™ — a 360-point comprehensive examination using 25 diagnostic methods. This system allowed him to identify the root cause of illness with remarkable precision, rather than simply treating symptoms.

Dr. Yeh held a Ph.D. in Acupuncture, an O.M.D. from both California and China, an M.D. from China, and a D.Sc. (Honorary). His concept of "Coded-In Temperature" (C.I.T.) — the idea that every food carries an inherent energetic temperature that affects the body — was a cornerstone of his clinical practice and a principle he applied with thousands of patients over his career.

Dr. Yeh passed away, leaving behind a legacy of healing and a body of knowledge that continues to help people understand the connection between food and health.

What Is Food Temperature in TCM?

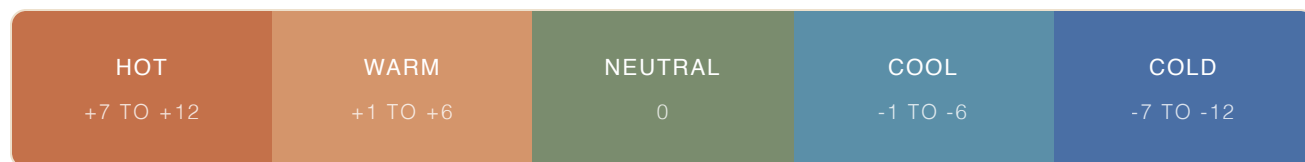
Every food you eat has a hidden property that has nothing to do with how hot or cold it feels in your mouth. In Traditional Chinese Medicine, this property is called the food's **internal temperature** — and it can profoundly affect your health.

Consider this: a chili pepper is classified as "hot" even when you eat it straight from the refrigerator. A slice of watermelon is "cold" even when served at room temperature on a summer afternoon. This internal temperature cannot be measured by any thermometer. It describes the *energetic effect* the food has on your body after you consume it.

Dr. Timothy Yeh called this concept "**Coded-In Temperature**" (C.I.T.). In his clinical practice, he observed that every food carries an inherent thermal quality — coded into the food itself — that either warms or cools the body from the inside.

The C.I.T. Scale

Dr. Yeh's system assigns each food a numerical value on a scale from **+12** (extremely hot) to **-12** (extremely cold), with **0** representing neutral.



This scale provides a more precise way to understand each food's thermal effect than simply labeling it "warming" or "cooling." A gentle warming herb like fresh ginger (+3) is quite different from the intense heat of dried cayenne pepper (+10).

Your Body's Thermostat

Your hypothalamus acts as your body's thermostat, maintaining a core temperature of 37°C (98.6°F). But here is the key insight from Dr. Yeh's system: each of your fourteen organ systems has its own internal temperature, and these temperatures can become imbalanced independently.

When an organ system runs too hot or too cold, symptoms appear. The lungs, the stomach, the liver — each can fall out of balance in its own way. The beauty of the C.I.T. system is that foods with specific internal temperatures can help restore balance to the affected organ systems.

KEY PRINCIPLE

Food temperature is not about the physical temperature of the food when you eat it. It is about the *thermal effect* that food produces inside your body after digestion. Two foods served at the same temperature on your plate can have opposite effects on your body's internal heat.

This is why your grandmother's chicken soup does more than just warm your hands — chicken is a warming food (+3 to +4 on the C.I.T. scale), and when combined with warming ginger and green onion, the soup actively helps raise the body's internal temperature and disperse cold.

Understanding this concept gives you a practical, everyday tool for managing your health through the foods you already eat.

The Five Temperature Categories

Every food falls into one of five categories based on its Coded-In Temperature. Understanding these categories is the foundation of using food as medicine.

+7 TO +12 ON THE C.I.T. SCALE

Hot Foods

Hot foods are strongly warming. They vigorously disperse cold, promote circulation, and stimulate metabolism. These are the most powerful warming foods and should be used with intention — overconsumption can lead to symptoms of excess heat such as inflammation, irritability, and dry mouth.

COMMON EXAMPLES

Cayenne pepper

Chili pepper

Black pepper

Cinnamon bark (Rou Gui)

Dried ginger

Raw garlic

Lamb / Mutton

Wine

Roasted sunflower seeds

Pineapple

Pineapple may surprise you. Despite being a tropical fruit, it has a hot internal temperature in the C.I.T. system. Many people who eat large amounts of pineapple notice mouth sores or skin breakouts — signs of excess heat.

+1 TO +6 ON THE C.I.T. SCALE

Warm Foods

Warm foods are gently warming and tonifying. They nourish yang energy, support digestion, and help the body maintain warmth without the intensity of hot foods. These are the everyday warming foods that most people can enjoy regularly.

COMMON EXAMPLES

Fresh ginger	Cooked garlic	Green onion	Chives	Leeks	Coffee	Cherries
Lychee fruit	Dried longan	Beef	Shrimp	Chicken	Coconut	Walnuts
Brown sugar	Cinnamon twig	Apricots	Peaches	Fennel	Anise seed	
Dried figs	Dried persimmon					

Notice that raw garlic is "hot" while cooked garlic is only "warm." Cooking can shift a food's internal temperature — a principle explored in Chapter 5.

0 ON THE C.I.T. SCALE

Neutral Foods

Neutral foods are gentle on the body and can be eaten year-round by almost everyone. They neither warm nor cool significantly, making them the safest foundation for any diet. Many staple grains, root vegetables, and common proteins fall into this category.

COMMON EXAMPLES

Brown rice	Oats	Sweet rice	Sweet potato	Corn	Potato	Taro	Carrots
Cabbage	Broccoli	Cauliflower	Napa cabbage	Shiitake mushrooms			
Tremella (white fungus)		Peanuts	Pine nuts	Sesame seeds	Apples	Grapes	
Figs	Mango	Loquat	Honey	Azuki red beans	Black-eyed peas	Broad beans	
Pork	Quail	Abalone	Soybean	Lily bulb	Lotus seed	Goji berries	

Tremella mushroom, goji berries, and lotus seeds are widely available at Asian grocery stores and online. They are staple ingredients in nourishing soups and desserts.

-1 TO -6 ON THE C.I.T. SCALE

Cool Foods

Cool foods are mildly cooling. They gently clear heat, nourish yin, and calm the body. They are appropriate for mild heat symptoms or for everyday use in warmer seasons. They are less intense than cold foods and rarely cause digestive upset.

COMMON EXAMPLES

Duck

Lemon

Lime

Persimmon

Bok choy

Pear

Aloe vera

American ginseng

Daikon radish (raw)

Celery

Cooked water chestnuts

Mint

Luffa

-7 TO -12 ON THE C.I.T. SCALE

Cold Foods

Cold foods are strongly cooling. They clear heat, purge fire, detoxify, and deeply nourish yin. These foods are most appropriate during hot weather or when the body shows signs of excess heat. People with weak digestion or cold constitutions should use them with caution.

COMMON EXAMPLES

Watermelon

Honeydew melon

Bitter melon

Banana

Grapefruit

Mung beans

Mung bean sprouts

Tofu

Spinach

Eggplant

Bamboo shoots

Green tea

Sea cucumber

Seaweed

Kelp

Cucumber

Tomato

Mung beans are available at most Asian grocery stores and many health food stores. They are one of the most effective cooling foods in TCM and are traditionally served as a sweet soup in summer.

How Temperature Connects to Your Organs

In Dr. Yeh's system, the body is not a single thermostat. Each organ system has its own internal temperature, and each can become imbalanced independently.

Understanding this connection is how food temperature becomes a practical healing tool.

When an organ system's temperature shifts out of its optimal range, symptoms appear. These symptoms fall into two broad categories:

HOT-STAGE SYNDROME

When an organ system runs too hot, you may experience:

- Inflammation and redness
- Irritability and restlessness
- Constipation and dark urine
- Dry mouth and excessive thirst
- Acne and skin eruptions
- Burning sensations
- Rapid pulse

Treatment principle: Use cool and cold foods to bring down the excess heat.

COLD-STAGE SYNDROME

When an organ system runs too cold, you may experience:

- Pale complexion
- Fatigue and low energy
- Cold hands and feet
- Loose stools and poor digestion
- Water retention
- Dull aches and stiffness
- Slow pulse

Treatment principle: Use warm and hot foods to restore internal warmth.

"Foods of a cold nature help the hot-stage syndrome. Foods of a cool nature help the warm-stage syndrome. Foods of a warm nature help the cool-stage syndrome. Foods of a hot nature help the cold-stage syndrome."

— Dr. Timothy Yeh

The Matching Principle

This is the elegant logic at the heart of food temperature therapy: **opposites balance**. The severity of the imbalance determines how strong a corrective food you need.

BODY CONDITION	SEVERITY	CORRECTIVE FOODS	EXAMPLES
Hot-stage syndrome	Severe excess heat	Cold Foods	Watermelon, mung bean soup, green tea
Warm-stage syndrome	Mild excess heat	Cool Foods	Pear, duck, mint tea, bok choy
Cool-stage syndrome	Mild deficient warmth	Warm Foods	Fresh ginger tea, chicken, walnuts
Cold-stage syndrome	Severe deficient warmth	Hot Foods	Lamb stew with ginger, cinnamon bark tea

Organ-Specific Patterns

While a comprehensive organ-by-organ analysis is beyond the scope of this guide, here are a few common patterns that illustrate how temperature imbalances manifest in specific organ systems:

STOMACH HEAT

Symptoms: excessive hunger, bad breath, bleeding gums, mouth sores, acid reflux. A stomach that runs too hot benefits from cooling foods like cucumber, watermelon, and mung beans.

LUNG DRYNESS (A FORM OF HEAT)

Symptoms: dry cough, dry skin, dry throat, nosebleeds. The lungs benefit from moistening, cooling foods like pear, lily bulb, tremella mushroom, and honey.

SPLEEN-STOMACH COLD

Symptoms: poor appetite, bloating after meals, loose stools, fatigue after eating. The digestive system benefits from warming foods like fresh ginger, cooked fennel, and warm brown rice porridge.

KIDNEY COLD

Symptoms: cold lower back, frequent urination (especially at night), fatigue, low drive. The kidneys benefit from deeply warming foods like lamb, walnuts, and cinnamon.

Reading Your Body's Signals

Your body is constantly telling you whether it is running too hot or too cold. Learning to read these signals is the first step toward using food temperature effectively.

The following checklist will help you assess your current thermal state. This is not a medical diagnosis — it is a simple self-awareness tool based on principles Dr. Yeh used in clinical practice.

SIGNS YOU MAY BE RUNNING HOT

- ☐ Feeling warm or flushed, especially in the face
- ☐ Frequently thirsty, craving cold drinks
- ☐ Constipation or dark-colored urine
- ☐ Irritability, restlessness, or difficulty sleeping
- ☐ Red tongue with yellow coating
- ☐ Acne, skin rashes, or redness
- ☐ Inflammation or swelling
- ☐ Canker sores or mouth ulcers
- ☐ Feeling overheated at night
- ☐ Strong body odor or bad breath

SIGNS YOU MAY BE RUNNING COLD

- ☐ Feeling chilly, cold hands and feet
- ☐ Preferring warm or hot drinks
- ☐ Loose stools or frequent urination
- ☐ Fatigue, low energy, or sluggishness
- ☐ Pale tongue with white coating
- ☐ Water retention or puffiness
- ☐ Dull complexion, pale lips
- ☐ Poor appetite, especially in the morning
- ☐ Aching joints that feel worse in cold weather
- ☐ Craving warm, hearty foods

Quick Self-Assessment

Count how many items you checked in each column. Use the guide below to get a general sense of your thermal tendency.

INTERPRETING YOUR RESULTS

Mostly "Hot" signs (5 or more): Your body may be accumulating excess heat. Focus on incorporating more cool and cold foods into your diet, especially during warmer months. Reduce consumption of hot and spicy foods, alcohol, and fried foods.

Mostly "Cold" signs (5 or more): Your body may lack sufficient internal warmth. Focus on incorporating more warm foods into your diet. Avoid excessive raw, cold, or icy foods and drinks. Warm, cooked meals will serve you better than cold salads and smoothies.

Mixed or few signs: Your body may be relatively balanced. Focus on neutral foods as your dietary foundation and make seasonal adjustments — slightly warming in winter, slightly cooling in summer.

Many signs in both columns: This may indicate a mixed or complex pattern. Consider consulting a qualified TCM practitioner for a personalized assessment.

A NOTE ON THE TONGUE

In TCM diagnosis, the tongue is considered a map of the internal organs. A red tongue with a yellow coating typically indicates heat, while a pale tongue with a white coating typically indicates cold. You can observe your own tongue first thing in the morning, before eating or drinking, for the most accurate reading. Look at it in natural light.

Tracking Over Time

Your thermal state is not fixed. It shifts with the seasons, with stress, with sleep, with what you eat, and with the natural changes of aging. What matters is developing the habit of checking in

with your body and adjusting your food choices accordingly.

Many of Dr. Yeh's patients learned to make these adjustments intuitively over time. They would notice the first signs of excess heat — perhaps a dry throat or a restless night — and naturally reach for a pear or a cup of chrysanthemum tea before the imbalance progressed.

This is food temperature therapy at its most practical: not a rigid system of rules, but a responsive relationship with your own body.

Balancing with Food Temperature

Now that you understand the five temperature categories and can read your body's signals, it is time to put this knowledge into practice. This chapter covers the strategies that Dr. Yeh's patients used to achieve thermal balance through everyday eating.

Strategy 1: Temperature Pairing

One of the most practical techniques is pairing warm and cool foods within a single meal. This creates balance on the plate rather than relying on any single food to do all the work.

CLASSIC PAIRINGS

- **Crab (cold) + ginger-vinegar dipping sauce (warm):** A traditional Chinese pairing that prevents the crab's strong cold nature from upsetting digestion.
- **Lamb (hot) + daikon radish (cool):** The radish tempers the lamb's intense heat.
- **Banana (cold) + walnuts and honey (warm/neutral):** A balanced snack combination.
- **Green tea (cold) + ginger (warm):** Adding fresh ginger to green tea reduces its cooling effect.

Strategy 2: Temperature Math

While you do not need to calculate exact C.I.T. values for every meal, it helps to think roughly about the overall temperature of what you are eating. If your dinner includes lamb (+8), black pepper (+9), and dried ginger (+8), that is a very hot meal. You would benefit from adding a cooling side — perhaps a cucumber salad (-8) or some steamed bok choy (-3).

The goal is not perfection. The goal is awareness. Over time, this kind of thinking becomes second nature.

Strategy 3: Cooking Methods Matter

How you prepare food can shift its internal temperature. This is a powerful tool for fine-tuning the thermal effect of your meals.

COOKING METHOD	EFFECT ON TEMPERATURE	NOTES
Raw / Cold preparation	Preserves or enhances cooling	Salads, smoothies, raw fruit
Steaming	Relatively neutral	Gentle method; preserves original temperature
Boiling / Simmering	Mildly warming	Soups and porridges are gently warming
Stir-frying	Moderately warming	High heat + oil adds warmth
Roasting / Baking	Warming	Dry heat concentrates warming qualities
Grilling / Charring	Strongly warming	Adds significant heat; use sparingly
Deep-frying	Strongly warming	High heat + oil creates substantial heat
Fermenting	Mildly warming	Fermentation generally adds warmth

This is why a raw salad is more cooling than a stir-fry made with the same vegetables. The cooking method itself adds thermal energy to the food.

Strategy 4: Seasonal Adjustments

Just as nature shifts through the seasons, so should your diet:

FALL & WINTER

- Favor warm and hot foods
- Choose cooked, warming preparations: soups, stews, roasted vegetables
- Use warming spices: ginger, cinnamon, fennel, black pepper
- Reduce raw and cold foods
- Drink warm beverages

SPRING & SUMMER

- Favor cool and cold foods
- Enjoy more raw vegetables, salads, and fresh fruit
- Use cooling herbs: mint, cilantro
- Incorporate watermelon, cucumber, mung bean soup
- Drink green tea and chrysanthemum tea

Strategy 5: Individual Adjustments

Beyond seasons, individual factors influence your baseline thermal state:

- **Constitution:** Some people naturally run warmer or cooler. Adjust your food temperature to complement your natural tendency.
- **Age:** As people age, they generally become cooler and drier. Elderly individuals often benefit from more warming, nourishing foods and fewer raw, cold foods.
- **Activity level:** Heavy physical exertion generates internal heat. Athletes and laborers may need more cooling foods to stay balanced.
- **Stress and emotions:** Chronic stress and strong emotions (especially anger and frustration) generate internal heat. During stressful periods, slightly cooling foods may help.
- **Pregnancy:** Pregnant women should generally avoid extremely hot or extremely cold foods and focus on the neutral-to-warm range. Always consult a healthcare provider.

THE 80/20 APPROACH

You do not need to analyze every bite. A practical approach: make about 80% of your diet neutral to mildly warm or cool foods (depending on your constitution and the season), and use the remaining 20% to fine-tune based on how you are feeling. If you notice heat symptoms, add more cooling foods. If you feel cold, add more warming ones.

Complete Food Temperature Reference

The following tables organize common foods by category, sorted from hottest to coldest. Use these as a quick reference when planning meals or when you want to check a specific food's thermal nature.

All foods listed here are available at regular grocery stores, Whole Foods, Asian grocery stores, or online retailers. Items marked with an asterisk () are most easily found at Asian grocery stores.*

Vegetables

FOOD	TEMPERATURE	C.I.T. RANGE	BEST SEASON
Dried ginger	Hot	+8 to +10	Winter
Raw garlic	Hot	+7 to +9	Winter
Fresh ginger	Warm	+3 to +5	Fall / Winter
Cooked garlic	Warm	+2 to +4	Year-round
Green onion (scallion)	Warm	+2 to +3	Fall / Winter
Chives	Warm	+2 to +4	Fall / Winter
Leeks	Warm	+1 to +3	Fall / Winter
Fennel	Warm	+2 to +3	Fall / Winter
Squash (winter varieties)	Warm	+1 to +2	Fall / Winter
Onion	Warm	+1 to +2	Year-round
Carrots	Neutral	0	Year-round
Cabbage	Neutral	0	Year-round
Broccoli	Neutral	0	Year-round
Cauliflower	Neutral	0	Year-round
Napa cabbage	Neutral	0	Year-round
Sweet potato	Neutral	0	Year-round
Potato	Neutral	0	Year-round

FOOD	TEMPERATURE	C.I.T. RANGE	BEST SEASON
Corn	Neutral	0	Summer / Fall
Taro*	Neutral	0	Year-round
Shiitake mushrooms	Neutral	0	Year-round
Bok choy*	Cool	-2 to -3	Spring / Summer
Celery	Cool	-1 to -3	Spring / Summer
Daikon radish* (raw)	Cool	-2 to -4	Spring / Summer
Luffa*	Cool	-2 to -4	Summer
Water chestnuts* (cooked)	Cool	-2 to -3	Summer
Spinach	Cold	-7 to -8	Spring / Summer
Eggplant	Cold	-7 to -8	Summer
Bamboo shoots*	Cold	-7 to -9	Summer
Bitter melon*	Cold	-8 to -10	Summer
Cucumber	Cold	-7 to -9	Summer
Tomato	Cold	-7 to -8	Summer

Fruits

FOOD	TEMPERATURE	C.I.T. RANGE	BEST SEASON
Pineapple	Hot	+7 to +9	Winter (sparingly)
Lychee fruit*	Warm	+3 to +5	Fall / Winter
Dried longan*	Warm	+3 to +5	Fall / Winter
Cherries	Warm	+2 to +4	Year-round
Peaches	Warm	+1 to +3	Year-round
Apricots	Warm	+1 to +3	Year-round
Dried figs	Warm	+1 to +2	Fall / Winter
Dried persimmon*	Warm	+1 to +2	Fall / Winter
Coconut	Warm	+1 to +3	Year-round
Jujube dates* (red dates)	Warm	+2 to +4	Fall / Winter
Apples	Neutral	0	Year-round
Grapes	Neutral	0	Year-round
Figs (fresh)	Neutral	0	Summer / Fall
Mango	Neutral	0	Summer
Loquat*	Neutral	0	Spring
Lemon	Cool	-1 to -3	Spring / Summer
Lime	Cool	-1 to -3	Spring / Summer

FOOD	TEMPERATURE	C.I.T. RANGE	BEST SEASON
Persimmon* (fresh)	Cool	-2 to -4	Fall
Pear	Cool	-3 to -5	Fall
Banana	Cold	-7 to -8	Summer
Grapefruit	Cold	-7 to -8	Summer
Watermelon	Cold	-9 to -11	Summer
Honeydew melon	Cold	-8 to -10	Summer

Proteins & Meats

FOOD	TEMPERATURE	C.I.T. RANGE	BEST SEASON
Lamb / Mutton	Hot	+7 to +9	Winter
Venison	Warm	+4 to +6	Fall / Winter
Shrimp	Warm	+3 to +5	Fall / Winter
Beef	Warm	+2 to +4	Fall / Winter
Chicken	Warm	+2 to +4	Year-round
Pork	Neutral	0	Year-round
Quail	Neutral	0	Year-round
Abalone*	Neutral	0	Year-round
Eggs	Neutral	0	Year-round
Salmon	Neutral	0	Year-round
Duck	Cool	-2 to -4	Summer
Crab	Cold	-7 to -9	Summer (with ginger)
Clams	Cold	-7 to -8	Summer
Sea cucumber*	Cold	-7 to -8	Summer

Grains & Legumes

FOOD	TEMPERATURE	C.I.T. RANGE	BEST SEASON
Glutinous (sweet) rice	Warm	+1 to +2	Fall / Winter
Oats	Neutral	0	Year-round
Brown rice	Neutral	0	Year-round
White rice	Neutral	0	Year-round
Azuki red beans*	Neutral	0	Year-round
Black-eyed peas	Neutral	0	Year-round
Broad beans (fava)	Neutral	0	Year-round
Soybeans	Neutral	0	Year-round
Lentils	Neutral	0	Year-round
Wheat	Cool	-1 to -2	Summer
Barley	Cool	-1 to -3	Summer
Mung beans*	Cold	-7 to -9	Summer
Tofu	Cold	-7 to -8	Summer

Nuts & Seeds

FOOD	TEMPERATURE	C.I.T. RANGE	BEST SEASON
Roasted sunflower seeds	Hot	+7 to +8	Winter
Walnuts	Warm	+2 to +4	Fall / Winter
Chestnuts	Warm	+1 to +3	Fall / Winter
Peanuts	Neutral	0	Year-round
Pine nuts	Neutral	0	Year-round
Sesame seeds	Neutral	0	Year-round
Almonds	Neutral	0	Year-round
Cashews	Neutral	0	Year-round
Lotus seeds*	Neutral	0	Year-round
Goji berries*	Neutral	0	Year-round

Seasonings & Spices

FOOD	TEMPERATURE	C.I.T. RANGE	BEST SEASON
Cayenne pepper	Hot	+9 to +11	Winter
Chili pepper (dried)	Hot	+8 to +10	Winter
Black pepper	Hot	+8 to +10	Winter
Cinnamon bark (Rou Gui)*	Hot	+8 to +10	Winter
Cinnamon twig (Gui Zhi)*	Warm	+3 to +5	Fall / Winter
Anise seed / Star anise	Warm	+2 to +4	Fall / Winter
Cumin	Warm	+2 to +4	Fall / Winter
Turmeric	Warm	+2 to +3	Fall / Winter
Brown sugar	Warm	+1 to +2	Fall / Winter
Honey	Neutral	0	Year-round
White sugar	Neutral	0	Year-round
Soy sauce	Neutral	0	Year-round
Mint	Cool	-2 to -4	Spring / Summer
Salt	Cool	-1 to -2	Year-round

Beverages

BEVERAGE	TEMPERATURE	C.I.T. RANGE	BEST SEASON
Wine (red or rice)	Hot	+7 to +9	Winter (in moderation)
Hard liquor	Hot	+8 to +10	Winter (in moderation)
Coffee	Warm	+2 to +4	Fall / Winter
Black tea	Warm	+1 to +3	Fall / Winter
Ginger tea	Warm	+3 to +5	Fall / Winter
Jujube tea*	Warm	+2 to +4	Fall / Winter
Water	Neutral	0	Year-round
Chrysanthemum tea*	Cool	-2 to -4	Spring / Summer
Peppermint tea	Cool	-2 to -4	Spring / Summer
Green tea	Cold	-7 to -8	Summer
Beer	Cold	-7 to -8	Summer (in moderation)

* Available at Asian grocery stores (such as 99 Ranch Market, H Mart, or similar), health food stores, or online retailers like Amazon.

Temperature-Based Meal Plans

The following meal plans show how to apply food temperature principles throughout a full day. Each plan uses ingredients you can find at a regular grocery store, with a few specialty items from Asian markets or the health food aisle.

The Cooling Day

Use this plan when you are experiencing signs of excess heat: feeling warm, irritable, constipated, or when the weather is very hot.

A Day of Cooling Foods

BREAKFAST

Overnight oats (neutral) with sliced banana (cold), fresh grapefruit segments (cold), and a drizzle of honey (neutral). Green tea (cold).

MID-MORNING SNACK

Fresh cucumber slices (cold) with a squeeze of lemon (cool). Peppermint tea (cool).

LUNCH

Spinach salad (cold) with sliced pear (cool), celery (cool), and tofu (cold), dressed with lemon juice and a pinch of salt. Barley water (cool) to drink.

AFTERNOON SNACK

Watermelon slices (cold) or mung bean soup (cold) served at room temperature.

DINNER

Steamed duck (cool) with bok choy (cool) and steamed brown rice (neutral). Cucumber and tomato side salad (cold). Chrysanthemum tea (cool).

The Warming Day

Use this plan when you are experiencing signs of cold: feeling chilly, fatigued, having cold hands and feet, or when the weather is cold.

A Day of Warming Foods

BREAKFAST

Warm oatmeal (neutral) with sliced peaches (warm), walnuts (warm), brown sugar (warm), and a pinch of cinnamon. Hot ginger tea (warm) with honey (neutral).

MID-MORNING SNACK

A handful of roasted chestnuts (warm) and a few dried apricots (warm). Black tea (warm).

LUNCH

Chicken soup (warm) with fresh ginger (warm), green onion (warm), carrots (neutral), and sweet potato (neutral). Steamed rice (neutral) on the side.

AFTERNOON SNACK

Cherries (warm) with a small handful of walnuts (warm). Coffee (warm) if desired.

DINNER

Beef stew (warm) with leeks (warm), fennel (warm), onion (warm), and potato (neutral). A side of roasted winter squash (warm) with a drizzle of honey.

The Balanced Day

Use this plan for everyday maintenance when your body feels relatively balanced, or as a template for moderate seasons like spring and fall.

A Day of Balanced Foods

BREAKFAST

Brown rice porridge (neutral) with goji berries (neutral), a few walnuts (warm), and a sliced apple (neutral). Warm water or mild black tea (warm).

MID-MORNING SNACK

An apple (neutral) with a small handful of almonds (neutral).

LUNCH

Stir-fried chicken (warm) with broccoli (neutral), carrots (neutral), and a few slices of fresh ginger (warm). Steamed rice (neutral).

AFTERNOON SNACK

Grapes (neutral) and pine nuts (neutral). Chrysanthemum tea (cool) or water.

DINNER

Steamed salmon (neutral) with sauteed cabbage (neutral), sweet potato (neutral), and a side of lightly dressed pear and celery salad (cool). A cup of warm water with lemon (cool).

TIPS FOR BUILDING YOUR OWN BALANCED MEALS

- Start with a neutral base: rice, oats, or potato.
- Add a protein that matches the season or your current needs.
- Include vegetables across the temperature spectrum.
- Use seasonings to fine-tune: a little ginger to warm up, a squeeze of lemon to cool down.
- Choose a beverage that complements or balances the meal's overall temperature.

Common Questions

Can cooking methods change a food's temperature?

Yes. Cooking generally shifts a food's temperature in the warming direction. Raw spinach, for example, is strongly cold. When you stir-fry it with garlic and ginger, the cooking method and the warming ingredients together create a more balanced dish. Grilling, roasting, and deep-frying add the most heat, while steaming is the most neutral cooking method. This is why TCM traditionally recommends cooked foods over raw for people with cold constitutions or weak digestion.

What about raw versus cooked foods?

Raw foods are inherently cooler than their cooked counterparts. A raw carrot is slightly cooler than a roasted carrot. This is one reason why TCM generally encourages cooked, warm meals — especially for breakfast and during colder months. Raw salads and smoothies, while nutritious, can be too cooling for people who already run cold. If you enjoy raw foods, balance them with warming ingredients like ginger, or enjoy them primarily during warmer seasons.

Do supplements and herbs have temperatures?

Absolutely. In TCM, every herb and natural supplement has a temperature classification, just like food. For example, American ginseng is cool, while Korean (Asian) ginseng is warm. Astragalus is warm, while chrysanthemum is cool. This is why it is important to choose supplements that match your body's needs. A supplement that is warming may help one person but worsen symptoms in someone who already has excess heat. Consult a qualified TCM practitioner for personalized herbal recommendations.

How does food temperature interact with medication?

Food temperature principles are part of a traditional dietary framework and are not a substitute for medical treatment. If you are taking prescription medication, continue to follow your doctor's guidance on diet. That said, the general principles of eating warming foods in cold weather and cooling foods in hot weather are broadly compatible with most medical advice. If you have specific concerns about dietary interactions with your medications, consult both your prescribing physician and a qualified TCM practitioner.

Can children follow this system?

The general principles of food temperature are applicable to people of all ages, including children. In TCM, children are considered to have immature digestive systems that are more sensitive to extremes. As a general guideline, children do best with neutral and mildly warm foods. Avoid giving very young children large amounts of extremely hot foods (like excessive chili or black pepper) or extremely cold foods (like large quantities of ice cream or iced drinks). Warm, cooked meals with a variety of vegetables, grains, and proteins are ideal for growing children.

Does food temperature change when you add ice or heat a food up?

No. This is one of the most important distinctions in the C.I.T. system. Adding ice to green tea makes it physically colder, but the green tea's internal temperature (cold, -7 to -8) remains the same. Similarly, heating up watermelon in a recipe does not change its cold C.I.T. value. The Coded-In Temperature is an inherent property of the food itself — it describes the effect the food has on your body's internal processes, not its physical temperature when served.

What if I eat a food from the "wrong" category?

There are no forbidden foods in this system. The goal is balance, not restriction. Eating a cold food when you are running cold will not cause immediate harm — but a consistent pattern of eating foods that worsen your imbalance can aggravate symptoms over time. Think of food temperature

as a gentle tool for daily self-care rather than a strict set of dietary rules. Even Dr. Yeh's patients ate across all temperature categories; the key was the overall balance of their diet over time.

Is this system scientifically proven?

Food temperature classification is part of a medical tradition that has been practiced for thousands of years. While modern clinical trials on the C.I.T. system specifically are limited, the broader principles of Traditional Chinese Medicine dietetics are well-documented in classical medical texts and continue to be taught in accredited TCM colleges worldwide. Dr. Yeh applied these principles with over 500,000 patients across five decades of clinical practice. As with any traditional system, we encourage you to observe how your own body responds to different foods and use that personal experience alongside the framework provided here.

Disclaimer

This guide is for educational and informational purposes only. It is not intended to diagnose, treat, cure, or prevent any disease or medical condition. The information presented here reflects traditional principles of Chinese medicine dietetics and the clinical experience of Dr. Timothy Yeh. It is not a substitute for professional medical advice. Always consult a qualified healthcare provider before making significant changes to your diet, especially if you are pregnant, nursing, taking medication, or managing a chronic condition.

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